Section 2 · Story 3

A Search Engine for Faces

Clearview AI · New York, USA · 2017 to today

Clearview AI, an American company founded in 2017, copies publicly posted photos from social media, news sites and other websites, without telling the people in them. Its software turns each face into a faceprint, a list of numbers describing its geometry. One uploaded photo can then find other photos of the same face online. By its own count, it holds more than 100 billion images, and it sells searches mainly to police and government agencies.

Regulators in Canada, Australia and several European countries found it broke their privacy laws. Canada's privacy commissioner said: "What Clearview does is mass surveillance and it is illegal." Illinois law draws its line at the faceprint: it protects scans of face geometry, but not photographs.

Clearview's co-founder, Hoan Ton-That, said: "All the data inside Clearview AI is publicly available, as it is with Google." The company says police use it to identify suspects and abused children. It admits no wrongdoing, and has not paid several European fines.

Status as of October 2026.

Nobody lost a photograph.
So what, if anything, was taken when the people in them became searchable?